Defections and Electoral Accountability

GS II

- In **representative democracy**, voters elect legislators to represent their interests in the Assembly. When an elected member resigns shortly after winning and joins another party, voters may face another election before the original representative has completed the expected term.

- India's **anti-defection law** seeks to discourage legislators from changing political allegiance in ways that undermine party-based electoral mandates. However, resignation followed by contesting a fresh election can create a different route for changing parties, raising questions about the law's effectiveness.

- **Ruling parties** may enjoy advantages in by-elections because voters expect their representatives to secure government attention and development support. This can influence electoral choices even when dissatisfaction exists, making a by-election victory an incomplete measure of public approval.

- Repeated resignations and party changes can weaken **political accountability** by shifting attention from public service to gaining political power. Although voters retain the right to accept or reject defecting candidates, electoral victories alone do not resolve concerns about institutional integrity.

Electoral accountability requires more than winning elections. Stable representation, responsible party conduct and safeguards against opportunistic defections help protect the democratic mandate.